

Examining the Relationship Between Schizophrenia and Substance Use Disorders

Letter to the Editor
Psychiatry Danubina, 2026; Vol. 38, No. 2, pp 221-228

Examining the relationship between schizophrenia and substance use disorders

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Schizophrenia and substance use disorders (SUDs) frequently co-occur, significantly complicating diagnosis, treatment, and recovery. Understanding the dynamic interaction between these conditions is critical in formulating effective clinical strategies and public health interventions. Schizophrenia is a chronic psychiatric disorder characterized by hallucinations, delusions, disorganized thinking, and social withdrawal. Approximately 40–60% of individuals with schizophrenia are also diagnosed with SUDs (Torrens et al., 2015). This overlap imposes a complex burden on patients, families, and healthcare systems.

Several hypotheses explain the link between schizophrenia and substance use. One prevailing theory is the self-medication hypothesis, wherein individuals use substances such as cannabis or alcohol to alleviate distressing symptoms like paranoia or auditory hallucinations (Khokhar et al., 2018). While this may offer temporary relief, it often worsens psychotic symptoms, reduces the effectiveness of antipsychotic medications, and increases the risk of relapse (Khokhar et al., 2018). Certain substances, particularly cannabis and amphetamines, are known to precipitate or exacerbate psychotic symptoms, especially in genetically predisposed individuals (Buyuksandalyaci Tunc & Gul, 2023). This raises causality concerns—whether substance use precedes psychosis or vice versa—creating diagnostic and therapeutic challenges.

Furthermore, co-occurring SUDs adversely affect the pharmacodynamics of antipsychotic medications. Substances like alcohol and nicotine can alter drug metabolism and reduce treatment efficacy, often requiring higher doses or leading to increased side effects such as sedation and metabolic syndrome (Wysokiński et al., 2023).

linking these disorders is essential. Moreover, public policy must support dual-diagnosis training and expand funding for integrated mental health services (Kumar et al., 2025).

In conclusion, schizophrenia and substance use disorders are interlinked in a complex, bidirectional relationship. Addressing them jointly through early intervention, integrated care, and stigma reduction is essential to improve clinical outcomes and patient quality of life.

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Description

Letter to the Editor published in *Psychiatry Danubina*, Volume 38, Issue 2 (2026), page 226. The article examines the clinical relationship between schizophrenia and substance use disorders, including diagnostic and treatment challenges and the importance of integrated mental-health care. The indexed record confirms the authors and publication details.

Source: HR██AK article record / *Psychiatry Danubina*. The article record identifies Volume 38, No. 2 (2026), page 226 and publication date 15 July 2026.